

Shortages of almost everything were a Confederate soldier's lot. He could expect a weapon and ammunition, plus a water canteen and tin cup, but most other items, from food to blankets and boots, were in short supply. Although officially clad in gray, Confederate troops often had to make do with homespun uniforms dyed with solutions of walnut shells and copper. Men marched barefoot, drawing a perverse pride from their evident raggedness. Soldiers dug rifle pits with tin cups for lack of shovels. Much of a soldier's time was devoted to scavenging for the basics of sustenance and kit.

Overcoats, blankets, and boots were plundered from captured Union stores or stolen from the Union dead and prisoners of war. Foraging Confederate soldiers pillaged farms in search of food or firewood, even though the people they robbed were civilians on their own side. This quest for necessities easily slipped into straightforward crime, with the theft of money and valuables.